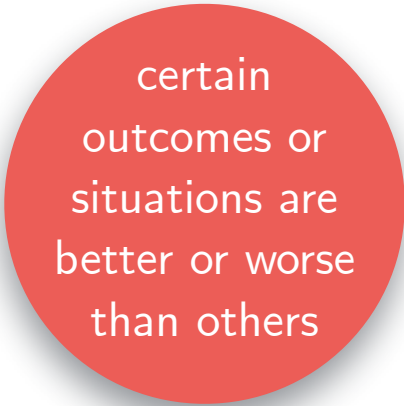




certain actions
are right or
wrong



certain
outcomes or
situations are
better or worse
than others

A solid green circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "certain people or lives are better or worse than others" is written in a white, sans-serif font, arranged in five lines.

certain
people or lives
are better or
worse than
others

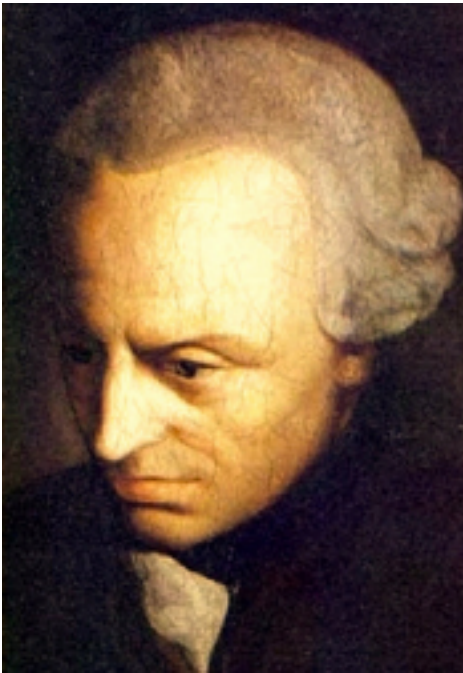
The consequentialist takes the goodness or badness of situations as fundamental, and tries to explain the others in terms of these. What would it look like if we took one of the other categories as most fundamental?

A **deontological** approach to what we ought to do takes facts about the rightness and wrongness of actions as basic, and does not try to explain the rightness or wrongness of actions in terms of the goodness or badness of the action's outcomes.

There are lots of different deontological theories. I'm going to briefly introduce you to one, which is based on the idea that people have certain basic **rights**. On this view, wrong actions are actions which violate someone's rights.

But what are rights, and which actions violate them?

One answer to this question was given by the 18th century German philosopher Immanuel Kant.



Kant thought that all human beings have dignity, and that this means that we all have the right not to be used as a way to satisfy the desires of others.

This kind of view has a lot to recommend it. But it also faces serious objections; let's look at two.

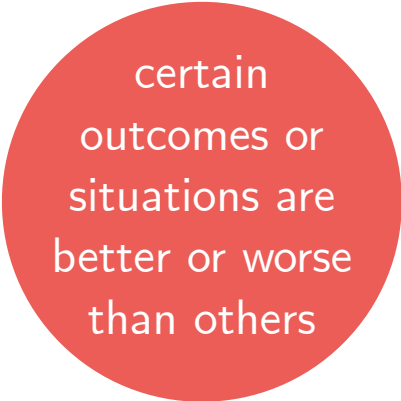
So now consider a situation in which I know that Dr. Evil is planning to use two innocent people as means to his ends. I can prevent this by lying to Dr. Evil, thereby using him as a means to my end of saving the innocents. Surely this is ok; rights-violations are supposed to be the bad thing, and I have prevented two while causing only one!

The first is sometimes called the **paradox of deontology**. The view of ethics we are considering says that rights-violations are the core of morality; they are what we are morally obliged to avoid.

The deontologist rejects this kind of consequentialist thinking. You must not treat Dr. Evil as a mere means, even if by doing so you can prevent him from using others as a mere means.



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